

Texas (Southwest): Audrey C., with only ninety days sobriety and at her first workshop, suggested the theme "To Live It—Give It" for our January Workshop. We wanted to have something centered around the Conference theme. "Preserving Our Fellowship—Our Challenge" is, actually, *my* challenge. So my personal challenge is to listen more, talk less, and pray. Our area has purchased translation equipment; this is important as we now have seven Spanish districts, 27 in all, and 442 groups. We have just appointed an ad hoc committee to consider budgets for all the area officers/committees. We have over 1,000 subscriptions for the Spanish Grapevine. Southwest Texas knows that there are other areas that love A.A. as much as we do, but we also know that there is no other area that loves A.A. more than we do.— *Tom McMullen*

Vermont: We have approximately 250 groups and hold four full area assemblies and six area committee meetings. Our convention this year picked the theme "Back to Basics." We have an active Grapevine chair and our out-going treasurer did a good job at making sure our finances were in order. My service sponsor some twenty-five years ago was Herb Morse, who was called office manager for years at the old G.S.O. when Bill W. was still alive. I'd like to pass along his message. He used to tell me: "Don't tell me how I'm doing it wrong—tell me how *we* can do it better."— *Don McGee*

Washington State East: Area 92, the first new area since 1973, includes small parts of four areas outside of Washington state, one of these being B.C. Yukon. We also include northern Idaho, a small piece of western Montana and a small piece of northeast Oregon. We decided to keep most of the existing Washington Area structure with three quarterlies and one assembly a year. That seems to have worked very well with over 40% of the registered groups coming to the assembly and 100% of the districts at all quarterlies. At our first quarterly we had 70-90 people, along with all of our 17 districts. We have approximately 400 groups in our new area. It is an honor beyond words to be allowed to be the first delegate from Washington State East Area.— *Ben Beigler*

Wisconsin (Northern)/Upper Peninsula Michigan: Area 74 serves over 600 registered groups through 22 districts. We hold two area conferences and two area assemblies. After years of struggling with the issue of a constitution and bylaws, the last assembly adopted guidelines that describe the area's service structure and its practices, screens area officer reimbursements, standing committee funding requests, and other budgetary matters. It was also empowered to investigate and report on such issues as prudent reserve and tax status, aiding in the development of an informed group conscience. Our Archives committee has begun to interview all members having 35 or more years of sobriety. This will preserve their experience, strength, and hope for future generations of alcoholics.— *Tom Canard*

Wyoming: We have 11 districts, 125 registered groups, and more than 2,000 members. We have two area assemblies; area conventions are held in May and October. Our finance committee enacted an area budget; our challenge is to adhere to this well-drafted work. All area committees are active; Grapevine and Archives have exhibits. Many districts have service workshops and area 76 for the most part is very much Big Book oriented. We have many meetings that aren't groups, which we try to encourage to become groups. Our small intimate groups are full of love and sharing. Our prayer is that we will always be united in Recovery and Service.— *Nina VanPatten*

Additional Committee Considerations That Did Not Result in Recommendations

Advisory Action 40 of the 1990 General Service Conference states: "Items discussed, but no action taken or recommendation made, as well as committee recommendations which are not adopted, be included in a separate section of the Final Conference Report." Those committee recommendations which are not adopted (less than 2/3 of the total Conference votes in favor), but which received at least a simple majority of the votes, are considered "strong suggestions" of the Conference. All items, listed by committee, are as follows:

AGENDA

- The committee reviewed the Conference Evaluation Questionnaire and forwarded to the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference some minor format changes.
- The committee asked the staff and trustees' Committee on Conference to search for ways to be sure that discussion and question time be available following presentations.
- The committee discussed the committee's conference calls and decided they should be held only on an "as needed" basis at the discretion of the chairperson of the trustees' Committee on the General Service Conference.

COOPERATION WITH THE PROFESSIONAL COMMUNITY

- The committee reviewed with appreciation the Progress Report of the trustees' C.P.C. Committee Review of C.P.C. Literature and Service Material. The committee made some modifications, and suggested that these:
 - a) Be returned to the trustees' C.P.C. Committee for their follow up; and that
 - b) after considering the Conference C.P.C. Committee's suggestions, a final report of the review of C.P.C. Literature and Service Material be prepared by the trustees' Committee on C.P.C. and forwarded to the 1997 Conference Committee on C.P.C.
- The committee reviewed the C.P.C. Workbook, and requested that a typographic omission of the word "other" in the explanatory line about Tradition Three on page 10 be fixed. The line ought to read "There are no other requirements for A.A. membership."
- The committee decided that since the C.P.C. Workbook was revised only last year, they would make no further changes this year.
- Although it might add a little expense and weight to the C.P.C. Kit, the committee would like to include in the kit the items (not already included) listed on page 29 of the C.P.C. Workbook; and also add a sample of the *About A.A.* sign-up card.

When Panel 45 delegate Sandra Kelly (Central Michigan) and her husband arrived at the hotel Saturday morning they discovered they had left their carry-on bag (containing return airline tickets, camera, grandchildren's pictures, etc.) in the taxi. After making the necessary phone calls, Sandra turned it over to God. At 8:00 am the next day the cab driver showed up at the hotel with the lost luggage. Who says New York is a cold town and cab drivers are not honest?

CORRECTIONAL FACILITIES

- The committee reviewed the Correctional Facilities Workbook and requested that the trustees' Correctional Facilities Committee prepare copy on youth detention centers, women's institutions, and short-term correctional facilities for the workbook, and present it to the 1997 Conference Correctional Facilities Committee for approval.

FINANCE

- The committee discussed the need for an alternative approach to pie charts and determined it was not necessary.
- The committee discussed the agenda item, "unless literature sales or contributions, or both, increase substantially we will have to raise prices and cut discounts or reduce services." Some thought this statement threatening while others saw it as a realistic assessment in light of the steady decline of contributions. The committee discussed finances in general and the spirit of the Seventh Tradition as it related to A.A. as a whole. It also discussed the need for education within the Fellowship. Raising the level of awareness through discussion may be one of the reasons for the increase of donations in the first quarter. Education could also decrease the "them vs. us" perception as well as the feeling that everyone does it "my way." We more clearly defined an overall goal, which is not necessarily to get groups to increase donations, or even to get groups who do not contribute to finally contribute but that donations are an expression of participation and gratitude. Everyone can claim ownership to a piece of the A.A. miracle, regardless of the size of his or her donation, and no one should be embarrassed if they can't send a large amount.
- The committee discussed methods of communication within the Fellowship and realized that there are many tools available to aid in the communication/education process. Some of these are:
 - a) "They [delegates] have the job of helping their committees obtain the financial support their areas and G.S.O. need." (*The A.A. Service Manual*, p. S69)
 - b) The Quarterly Contribution Letter, sent to delegates by G.S.O., which reflects area contribution activity.
 - c) Quarterly Contribution Reports, sent by G.S.O. to the delegates, with group contribution activity.
 - d) Quarterly Contribution Letter, sent by G.S.O. to each group, reflects the group's contribution activity.
 - e) General Service Conference presentations.
 - f) General Service *Final Conference Report* to each group.
 - g) A.A.W.S. Highlights.
 - h) *Box 4-5-9*.
 - i) Regional service assemblies.
 - j) Regional Forums information that can be disseminated further to those who were not able to attend.
 - k) Invite speakers to local/regional events.
 - l) Area information packages generated by each area and an emphasis on the delegate's use of: the new services video, when available; the Inflation Chart, What's Wrong With This Picture flyer.
- The committee also felt that more detailed, fully-encompassing information should be available concerning the routine services G.S.O. provides—such as free literature, translations, new

items published, and awards received. Perhaps the delegates should approach the education of their area as a challenge to sustain the spirit of the Seventh Tradition.

GRAPEVINE

- The committee discussed returning the "About Alcoholism" section (gray pages) to the Grapevine and felt that no action was necessary. The committee saw no clear need or desire in the Fellowship for the section. Information from the alcoholism field does not promote A.A.'s primary purpose and is readily available elsewhere.
- The committee discussed several suggestions for related materials for possible production in 1998 and forwarded to the Grapevine Corporate Board for development: 1) a third volume of *Best of the Grapevine*, and 2) audio recordings by and about young people in Alcoholics Anonymous.
- The committee discussed a suggested rewording of the A.A. Preamble and felt that no change is needed.
- The committee reviewed the A.A. Grapevine Workbook and endorsed it with minor editorial changes and updating.

INTERNATIONAL CONVENTIONS/REGIONAL FORUMS

- The committee suggested that at the 1997 joint meeting of the Conference and trustees' Committees on International Conventions/Regional Forums there be a review of the background information that led to the 1995 Conference Policy and Admissions Advisory Action: "The Conference Committee on International Conventions continue to meet on an annual basis, discussing Regional Forums when there are no International Convention items; and that the committee be renamed Conference Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums."
- The committee also suggested that at the 1997 joint meeting of the Conference and trustees' Committees on International Conventions/Regional Forums, a Composition, Scope and Procedure for the Conference Committee on International Conventions/Regional Forums be discussed.
- After lengthy discussion, the committee agreed that all current Convention Site Committee members participate in voting for possible site cities for the International Convention in 2005.

LITERATURE

- The committee discussed whether a story of a bisexual alcoholic be included in the pamphlet, "Do You Think You're Different?" and made no recommendations.
- In light of the fact that *Box 4-5-9* is in the process of preparing an article on the importance of sharing our experience, strength

Another Small Miracle

When Rodney Rabren left SE Texas for the Conference, his new grandson was in critical condition. "I came here to do what I could to carry the message and God did His job with my problems at home," said Rodney. When he returned to Texas his grandson was there to meet him. "When I came to A.A. I was told that if I did my job to stay sober and help others, God would take care of the rest. This is so clear to me today."

and hope with newcomers in regard to confidentiality within Alcoholics Anonymous, the committee decided to defer the decision for publication of other material in regard to confidentiality and review the question again at the 1997 General Service Conference.

- The committee considered a request for a pamphlet directed to the concerns of the nonbeliever (atheist and/or agnostic) and made no recommendations.
- The committee considered a request for feedback and further guidance on how to proceed concerning the topic of Big Book Questionnaire and Outline and decided not to proceed with a questionnaire at this time.

POLICY/ADMISSIONS

- The committee discussed the issue of floor actions and suggested that the committees responsible continue to establish the Conference agenda's order of business.
- The committee discussed requests to identify the source of agenda items and concluded that the proper procedures are already in place.
- The committee discussed the policy for Conference observers and suggested that the trustees' Committee on the Conference create a guideline letter explaining the role of an observer.
- The committee discussed the feasibility of forming a Conference Archives Committee and determined that at present a sufficient need had not been articulated. The committee further asked that any additional input from areas on this issue be forwarded to the trustees' Archives Committee for further review.
- The committee discussed the future growth of the Conference and its effect on A.A. as a whole and suggested that the trustees' Committee on the Conference furnish a report with more guidance on this issue for the Conference Policy/Admissions Committee at the 47th General Service Conference.
- The committee discussed a request from the Conference Literature Committee to approve filming in designated areas of the Conference and took no action.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

- The committee reviewed the 1996 Membership Survey Questionnaire approved by the 1995 General Service Conference and decided to make no changes.
- The committee discussed at length the proposal to remove the following questions from the 1996 Membership Survey Questionnaire: race; marital status; anything to do with drugs; and decided unanimously to take no action on this proposal. The committee recognized that there is no reference to drugs in the 1996 Membership Survey Questionnaire approved by the 1995 General Service Conference.
- The committee considered a request to undertake a complete review of public information pamphlets looking for duplication with other A.A. literature and emphasis on A.A.'s primary purpose and agreed that there was no need to undertake a complete review of public information pamphlets at this time.
- The committee deferred discussion of the A.A. Web Site as a public information tool until the 1997 General Service Conference.
- The committee reviewed the Public Information Workbook and suggested that information about "cards and signs" and "tele-

phone directories" be added to the Workbook. The committee also suggested that the following information be added to the Public Information Workbook folder: Radio and television public service announcement scripts; service piece "Suggestions for Working with Your Local Radio and Television Stations to Help Carry the Message"; and service piece "A.A. Fact Sheet."

REPORT AND CHARTER

- After reviewing the chart submitted, illustrating Third Legacy Procedure, the committee agreed that an illustration in *The A.A. Service Manual* might help people new in general service understand the procedure and suggested that diagrams of Third Legacy Procedure be prepared for consideration by the 1997 Conference Report and Charter Committee.
- The committee discussed clarifying who is eligible to vote in the "How Do We Elect the D.C.M." section of *The A.A. Service Manual* and agreed that the current information is adequate since *The A.A. Service Manual* offers some options, and districts and areas may determine the best way to conduct their elections.
- The committee considered adding a footnote to "A Resolution" on page S35 of *The A.A. Service Manual* indicating that the 1995 General Service Conference recommended that the first 164 pages of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, the Preface, the Forewords, "The Doctor's Opinion," "Doctor Bob's Nightmare" and the Appendices remain as is and decided that no action is necessary since the Conference has historically resisted any effort to change the Big Book, with the exception of updating some of the stories.
- The committee discussed whether or not the first 164 pages of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, should have the same rewrite status as the Steps, Traditions, and Warranties of Article XII of the Conference Charter. Since one Conference's actions are not binding on another and the Conference has historically resisted any effort to change the Big Book in any way other than updating stories, the committee saw no need for a recommendation.
- The committee considered a small, two-or three-ring-binder format for *The A.A. Service Manual* and agreed that it is not financially feasible.
- The committee considered printing *The A.A. Service Manual* every two to five years and agreed that the practice of printing *The A.A. Service Manual* annually should continue, since the Fellowship should be kept informed and savings would be negligible.
- The committee considered the need for a footnote following the Introduction in *Twelve Concepts for World Service* indicating that, with permission of A.A. World Services, other Twelve Step programs, as well as A.A. service structures in other countries, have adapted their own Twelve Concepts, rewording them in an appropriate manner to reflect their own governmental/legal requirements and service structures. It was the consensus that this matter be reviewed by the 1997 Conference Report and Charter Committee to allow time to gather additional background information with regard to which body ultimately has responsibility for granting such permission.
- The committee reviewed the action of the 1995 Conference that resulted in the inclusion in the *Final Report* of proposed floor actions that the Conference voted not to consider and agreed that it was appropriate to include that information.
- The committee asked that consideration be given to listing online groups/meetings on A.A.'s Web Site.

TREATMENT FACILITIES

- The committee reviewed and discussed the sampling survey on Treatment Facility items conducted by the chairperson and alternate chairperson of the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee, beginning with Item No. 6: Do you or your committee have any concerns that you would like to have discussed by the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee? Helpful suggestions in response to concerns were: Encouraging areas to get more districts involved in treatment facilities service work; having more treatment facilities workshops; making service calls to treatment facilities; encouraging more discussion on carrying the message into treatment facilities; emphasizing Bridging the Gap service work. *Improvement in communication is always desired, especially in the current changing treatment environment.*
- The committee discussed the future direction of the Conference Treatment Facilities Committee and referred to the 1997 Conference Treatment Facilities Committee the review of both the committee's scope and its literature to make sure that the changing landscape of treatment programs is reflected.
- The committee discussed ways to inform the Fellowship about current changes going on in the treatment field and encouraged the A.A. membership to share these changes with the Treatment Facilities desk at the General Service Office.
- The committee shared ways to get "temporary contacts" for patients at the beginning of their treatment and felt that providing "temporary contacts" or "bridging the gap" contacts should be left up to the autonomy of the Treatment Facility Committee involved. Suggestions were also made to use central/intergroup office lists, area Treatment Facilities Committee chairpersons and "bridging the gap" committees as a means for "temporary contact" service work.
- The committee considered adding material to the Treatment Facilities Workbook on making Twelfth Step calls on "wet drunks" and, although the committee recognized the importance for each of us to understand working with others, it was decided the Treatment Facilities Workbook was not the proper format for this material. The committee referred the subject of making Twelfth Step calls on "wet drunks" to the trustees' Treatment Facilities Committee for further discussion.

CONFERENCE COMMITTEE ON TRUSTEES

- No other considerations.

Committee Recommendations Which Did Not Result in Conference Advisory Actions

GRAPEVINE

- The committee recommended that the Grapevine Corporate Board and staff utilize mailing lists similar to those used by the General Service Office to disseminate information about the Grapevine.

LITERATURE

- It was recommended that the video production company be authorized to videotape a short piece of the 46th General

Service Conference session (as well as a committee meeting) for possible limited use in the video project recommended by the 45th General Service Conference, subject to proper safeguards for anonymity, with no individually identifiable faces or voices. The video project will be brought back to the General Service Conference through the trustees' Literature Committee and the 47th General Service Conference Literature Committee for Conference approval.

- It was recommended that the manuscript originally commissioned as a history book be relabeled "collected observations of Alcoholics Anonymous" and that it be placed in the Archives and made available for purchase at cost upon request after editing for anonymity and various specific concerns relating to accuracy of content and style.
- It was recommended that the "Landmarks in A.A. History" section of *A.A. Comes of Age* be returned to its original form, as published in 1957, at the next printing.

REPORT AND CHARTER

- With a clear understanding that groups listed in the directory are listed at their own request, and a directory listing does not constitute or imply approval or endorsement of any group's approach to or practice of the traditional A.A. program, the committee recommended that online A.A. groups/meetings be listed in A.A. Directories on a supplementary page at the end of the Individual Groups section under the heading "Online Groups/Meetings," and that an e-mail or equivalent URL (Universal Resource Listing) contact address be provided in place of a contact person's phone number.
- Recognizing the unique characteristics of online groups with membership in many areas throughout the U.S. and Canada and also internationally, the committee recommended that members of online groups/meetings participate in the general service structure through regular face-to-face groups meeting in one location.

Floor Actions Which Did Not Result in Conference Advisory Actions

Floor Action #1:

Propose a Conference resolution that the 46th General Service Conference recommend to the Fellowship of A.A.s of the world that the first 164 pages of the Big Book, *Alcoholics Anonymous*, the Preface, the Forewords, "The Doctor's Opinion," "Doctor Bob's Nightmare" and the Appendices be unchanged without approval of three quarters of groups of the world.

Floor Action #2:

Propose a Conference recommendation that the General Service Board and its subsidiary boards, A.A. World Services Inc. and The A.A. Grapevine, Inc., initiate no litigation regarding the protection of copyrights or trademarks.

Wrong Door!

In his confusion the first day, John Kane (Southern New Jersey) walked into the ladies room by mistake and ran right into Wendy Zapaniuk (Saskatchewan). Rushing out, flustered, John said: "I haven't done that since I was drinking!" Wendy, holding her sides laughing: "That's the first time sober I've been followed into a John by a John."